

Chapter

The Power of Dharana — A Horse in the Dung, Tears Among the Gifts



Introduction: Sorrow Does Not Come from Outside

We usually believe that joy and sorrow come from circumstances — get something good and we are happy, get something bad and we suffer. Acharya Upendra Ji overturns this belief with a short, delightful story. He begins by saying:

"'I am sad, I am very sad' — people who say this come to play the game of sorrow."

"Sorrow comes from within. Such a person sees only sorrow in everything. However good a thing you bring them, whatever you bring, they will still see only sorrow."

At the centre of this chapter is one word — **dharana shakti**, the power of holding: which feeling the mind has taken hold of within, joy or sorrow. Let us understand it through the story.

Two Sons, One Puzzle

The story is about a father and his two sons:

"Once a father had two sons. Of the two, one was always happy, and one was always unhappy."

The father could not understand why:

"So even the father couldn't understand how this boy is happy every time, and how the other one, give him anything, is unhappy."

The Father's Test: Reversed Gifts

So the father decides to try an experiment. On the occasion of a festival, he plans to give the two of them gifts that would turn their natures upside down:

"Let's give them such a gift that this happy one becomes unhappy at least once — I'll see; and let me see whether the unhappy one is ever happy."

At night, while both are asleep, the father fills the happy son's room with horse dung:

"In one son's room he spreads horse dung everywhere — like cow dung — all over the floor. Even when he gets up, his foot will land in it."

And the unhappy son's room with toys:

"In the other child's room, everywhere, he puts those digital, remote-controlled things — the latest cars, this and that, everything — so that when he wakes up he will be happy, seeing so many gifts."

The father was certain that the next morning everything would be reversed. But Acharya Ji hints right here at why it won't be:

"But that is the power of dharana, isn't it — that is what is held within. This one has taken hold of joy alone; that one has taken hold of sorrow alone."

The Morning Scene: A Dance in the Mud

The happy son wakes up first — and Acharya Ji gives the reason:

"The next morning, the happy one wakes up first, because he has a fresh mind; there is no tamas in him."

Tamas — of the three qualities of nature (sattva, rajas, tamas), the one that signifies inertia, lethargy and darkness. A cheerful mind does not carry the weight of tamas, so it wakes up easily.

The father stands ready, expecting the boy to cry so he will have to console him. But the exact opposite happens:

"As soon as he puts his foot down — all that dung — he jumps into it and becomes even happier. The way children dance in mud, he starts dancing more and more and more. It splashes here, it splashes there on the wall — he doesn't have a care in the world."

Tears Among the Toys

The other son is woken by the noise. Seeing remote-controlled cars all around him, at first he thinks Santa Claus must have come. But the very next moment:

"But as soon as he saw them — instantly, tears in his eyes. The next minute, the father is even more tense."

"Where Is the Horse?" — The Logic of a Happy Mind

The bewildered father asks the happy son, "Why are you dancing?" And the answer is the heart of this story:

"Papa, there is all this horse stuff here, all this dung around — so that means there must be a horse somewhere nearby! If not a big horse, you must have brought me at least a small one. Where is it, tell me! I want to ride it right now."

"I am fully positive-minded person. It is my samskara from past lives — in everything; my mother taught me. Where is the horse, show me! I've come for that horse, that's why I'm dancing."

Where anyone else would have seen only filth, this child saw **the gift hidden behind the filth**. Notice that he even names the source of his outlook — **samskara**, the deep impressions left on the mind by past lives and upbringing.

"Who Will Run Them?" — The Logic of an Unhappy Mind

Then the father asks the unhappy son, "Why are you sad?" The answer comes at once:

"Arre, who is going to run so many cars? Then the battery... the battery will run out, and at the shop — you'll tell me 'go, bring it yourself', or else you won't bring it for four days, you'll say 'I'm busy'. So how will I play? What will I do with them?"

A pile of gifts lies in front of him, yet this mind abandons the joy of the present and manufactures problems for the future — the battery will die, Papa won't buy more, I won't be able to play. Acharya Ji sums up the scene in a single line:

"His crying starts, and this one's joy starts."

The Essence of the Story: The Power of Dharana

At the end, Acharya Ji asks the question himself and answers it:

"What did you learn from this story? About dharana shakti. It was a very big lesson about the power of dharana."

"This sorrow is by default, inbuilt — it is held from within. It doesn't have to be brought in separately."

"His mind accepted — every time, sorrow, sorrow, sorrow; and in this one's mind, joy, joy, positivity."

The circumstances were deliberately reversed — and still the outcome did not change. The happy boy found a celebration even in dung; the unhappy boy found worry even among toys. **It is not the scene outside but the dharana within that decides what we experience.**

Key Teachings

- 1 Sorrow comes from within.** For a mind that holds sorrow, "however good a thing you bring, it will still see only sorrow."
- 2 The power of dharana is decisive.** "This one has taken hold of joy alone; that one has taken hold of sorrow alone" — changing the circumstances does not change this.

- 3 A happy mind sees possibility in every situation.**
Seeing the dung, he thought — "there must be a horse somewhere."
- 4 An unhappy mind manufactures a problem out of every gift.** Even among the toys, his worry was — "who will run them? The battery will run out."
- 5 A cheerful mind has no tamas.** The happy boy had a "fresh mind," and so he woke first.
- 6 This outlook comes from samskara.** "It is my samskara from past lives... my mother taught me" — what we sow within becomes the way we see.